

The French Revolution set out with the idea of building a new state that would take the Enlightenment principles of liberty, equality, and brotherhood as its foundation.

Liberté

A new understanding of liberty suggested that all were free to behave as they chose if they did no harm to others.



Égalité

This idea asserted that all people were equal under the law and ended aristocratic privilege.



Fraternité

This was the hope that the revolution would usher in a newfound, rational spirit of brotherhood.

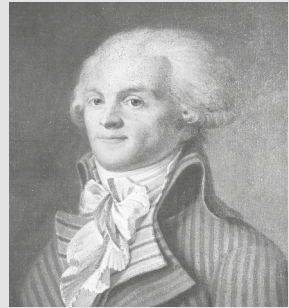


defeats, apparently poised to carry the revolution into new territories. Emboldened, France reinforced its assertion of what it claimed were its "natural frontiers" on the Rhine, which in reality meant an audacious extension of French rule into Germany. By 1797, it had inflicted crushing defeats over Austria in the Low Countries and in northern Italy. France was ready to reassert what it saw as its natural primacy in Europe.

Historical significance

Whatever the importance of the French Revolution, it remains the subject of continuing and intense historical debate. Its notional goals were clear: the ending of repressive monarchy and entrenched privilege; the establishment of representative government; and the championing of universal rights. But the reality was confused and often violent.

Furthermore, by 1804 Napoleon had effectively swapped one form of absolutism for his own, albeit one vastly more effective than any France had known since Louis XIV. Yet the revolution's consequences reverberated well into the 20th century. It remains a pivotal moment in the belief that freedom should underpin the civilized world. ■



Maximilien Robespierre

Robespierre (1758–1794), a lawyer and a member of the third estate in 1789, was the chief architect of the Terror that gripped France between September 1793 and July 1794. He was a consistent champion of the dispossessed, as well as a remarkable orator, capable of astonishingly intense speeches that electrified his supporters and opponents alike. He was also a fierce opponent of the Revolutionary Wars, believing that a strengthened army risked becoming a source of counterrevolutionary fervor. Initially, at least, he was also opposed to the death penalty. His change of mind was startlingly absolute. When persuaded that terror was the most effective means of preserving the revolution, he embraced it implacably, arguing that it was the natural handmaiden of the virtue he felt should drive the revolution. He remains the original, chilling model for all those who have since championed state violence in the interests of a supposed greater good.